THE POLITICS OF ACCURACY IN AI DIVINATION: EXPLAINABILITY AND INEFFABILITY

ABSTRACT
This study examines the rise of AI-powered fortune-telling, focusing on how users perceive accuracy in digital divination. Unlike conventional AI systems that prioritize explainability and empirical validation, AI divination operates on subjective interpretation and trust in opaque algorithms. Through qualitative research, this paper explores how users engage with AI for fortune-telling, negotiate accuracy, and willingly share personal data despite privacy concerns. By analyzing AI's role in digital spirituality, this study provides insights into the intersection of technology, belief systems, and algorithmic trust, contributing to discussions on AI explainability, privacy, and the evolving relationship between humans and artificial intelligence.

KEYWORDS
AI divination, explainable AI, ineffability, digital spirituality

INTRODUCTION
"Oh my god, DeepSeek's fortune-telling results are so accurate! You all have to try this!" Following DeepSeek's sensational debut in January, one of the earliest trends in its use across China was, surprisingly, AI fortune-telling. On social media, users eagerly shared their prompts and AI-generated readings, repurposing an advanced machine-learning model for spiritual and metaphysical insight. However, this research does not seek to examine the philosophy of ancient mythology. Instead, it situates AI divination at the intersection of socio-technical systems, posing a central yet deceptively simple question: When users claim AI divination is accurate, what does accuracy really mean?

This concept is interrogated through three key steps of AI use in users' divination: techno-mythological context, dialogue, and reflection, each corresponding to a research question. First, what socio-technical and cultural contexts shape users' perceptions of accuracy, and how do they make sense of this hybrid techno-mythological algorithm (RQ1)? Second, how do users interact with AI divination systems, and what practices emerge around prompt crafting, data sharing, and accuracy negotiation (RQ2)? Third, what does accuracy mean in the AI-fortune-telling activities (RQ3)?

EXPLAIN OR NOT TO EXPLAIN?

Accuracy in AI fortune-telling differs fundamentally from typical predictive AI applications. While conventional AI defines accuracy rationally and empirically, divination frames accuracy as subjective, relational, and ineffable—something deeply felt yet difficult to articulate. Explainable AI (XAI) research emphasizes that trust emerges from transparency in algorithmic decision-making (Doshi-Velez & Kim, 2017) as users can rationally justify AI's reliability.

While explainable AI research focuses on rationalizing AI systems, digital spirituality studies examine how AI is absorbed into mystical and religious imaginaries, such as telepathy, clairvoyance, and mind-reading (Natale, 2019). AI is often marketed as an enchanted system, with its inner workings deliberately obscured to maintain an aura of mystery (Nagy & Neff, 2024). In this vein, digital divination, as "sacralized randomness" (Ruah-Midbar, 2014) highlights ineffability (Lustig and Rosner, 2022)—the inability to explain why something feels true—as a fundamental element of trust in technology. Going back to the question of accuracy, this raises a critical question about whether opacity, rather than transparency, might better foster trust and belief in such techno-cosmological contexts.

Through a mixed-methods approach, this study will examine this accuracy politics by analyzing textual artifacts such as prompt templates, AI-generated divination readings, and social media discourse, and in-progress semi-structured interviews to explore how users interact with AI-generated divinations, negotiate accuracy, and engage in meaning-making practices.

CONCLUSION

This research aims to contribute to broader discussions on techno-spirituality, explainability in AI, and algorithmic mysticism. The rise of AI-powered divination is not merely a technological novelty but a site of cultural and epistemic transformation, where belief in data, mythology, and computational systems converges to create new forms of algorithmic faith.

GENERATIVE AI USE

I employed AI tools for the following purposes: brainstorming and polishing articles. I evaluated the output by carefully reviewing, fact-checking and revising the content for originality and writing style. The authors assume all responsibility for the content of this submission.

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